AI WITH MUDIT

BEGINNER GUIDE
NOTEBOOKLM EDITION
UPDATED 2026

LEARN FASTER WITH AI THAT ONLY USES YOUR SOURCES

Turn sources into understanding

Drop in videos, PDFs, and articles. Get notes, quizzes, audio, scripts, and real understanding back, with every answer pointing to exactly where it came from.

FOR
Students, creators, and curious people. Zero setup.

YOU BUILD
Notebooks that turn your sources into deep understanding.

YOU GET
Notes, quizzes, audio, and content, all backed by citations.

A practical, come back to it guide.
Open NotebookLM next to it and
build one notebook as you read.

DM "LEARN"

READ ME FIRST

How to use this guide

This is a workbook, not a blog post. By the last page you can open NotebookLM and turn any video, PDF, or topic into real understanding, starting from zero.

OPEN IT SIDE BY SIDE

Keep NotebookLM open in another tab while you read. Do each step for real, even with a random YouTube video.

COPY THE PROMPTS

Copy the prompts exactly the first time. Once you see how they behave, start making them your own.

DO THIS NOW

The coral boxes are small actions. Doing them is what turns this from reading into a real skill.

WHAT YOU SHOULD SEE

The green boxes show roughly what good output looks like, so you know you are on the right track.

> **Your goal is not more AI output.** It is clearer understanding. NotebookLM can make a hundred things. This guide is about making the few that actually teach you something.

DO THIS NOW

Pick one thing you want to learn or study this week. A chapter, a YouTube lecture, a topic you are curious about. Keep it in mind. You will build a real notebook for it by the end.

THE ONE IDEA THAT MATTERS

ChatGPT answers you. This answers from your sources.

That one difference is the whole point. NotebookLM is a free tool from Google that only uses the material you give it, and it shows you exactly where each answer came from.

A NORMAL AI CHAT

Answers from everything it learned across the whole internet. Great for brainstorming and writing. But it can mix things up or make things sound true when they are not.

NOTEBOOKLM

Answers only from the sources you upload. It summarizes, explains, quizzes, and cites them. Far fewer made up facts, because it is reading your material, not guessing.

THE MENTAL MODEL



> **Why this is a big deal for studying.** When AI can only use your textbook, your lecture, and your notes, its answers are about your actual exam, not some random version of the topic from the internet.

PICK THE RIGHT TOOL

When to use NotebookLM, and when not to

It is not a ChatGPT replacement. It is a different tool for a different job. Knowing which to open saves you a lot of frustration.

REACH FOR NOTEBOOKLM

- You have sources and need to understand them fast.
- You want summaries, quizzes, or citations from those exact sources.
- You are studying a chapter, researching, or going down a topic rabbit hole.

REACH FOR CHATGPT OR GEMINI

- You need knowledge from outside your sources.
- You want to brainstorm or write something from scratch.
- You want pure creativity, not source backed answers.

> **Simple split.** Outside knowledge and fresh ideas, use a normal chatbot. Understanding your own material deeply and being able to trust it, use NotebookLM. Many people use both, for different steps.

PART 01

Open it and learn the screen

The part no guide explains. How to actually open NotebookLM, what the three panels are, how to add sources, and what a citation is. Get this and the rest is easy.

05 Open it and sign in

06 The screen: Sources, Chat, Studio

07 What a notebook and source are

08 Add your first sources

09 Citations: click for proof

10 Chat vs Studio

11 Free, private, and the limits

12 Your first notebook in 10 minutes

FIRST, GET IN

Open it and sign in

NotebookLM is free. You do not install anything on a computer. You open a web page and sign in with a Google account. There is a phone app too.

1. **Go to the website**
   Open notebooklm.google.com in any browser, on a laptop or phone.
2. **Sign in with Google**
   Use the same account as your Gmail. It is free. No card, no payment.
3. **Click Create**
   Hit Create or New Notebook. That blank notebook is your first project.
4. **Phone optional**
   There is a NotebookLM app for iOS and Android. The web version has the most features, so learn on a laptop if you can.

WHAT YOU SHOULD SEE

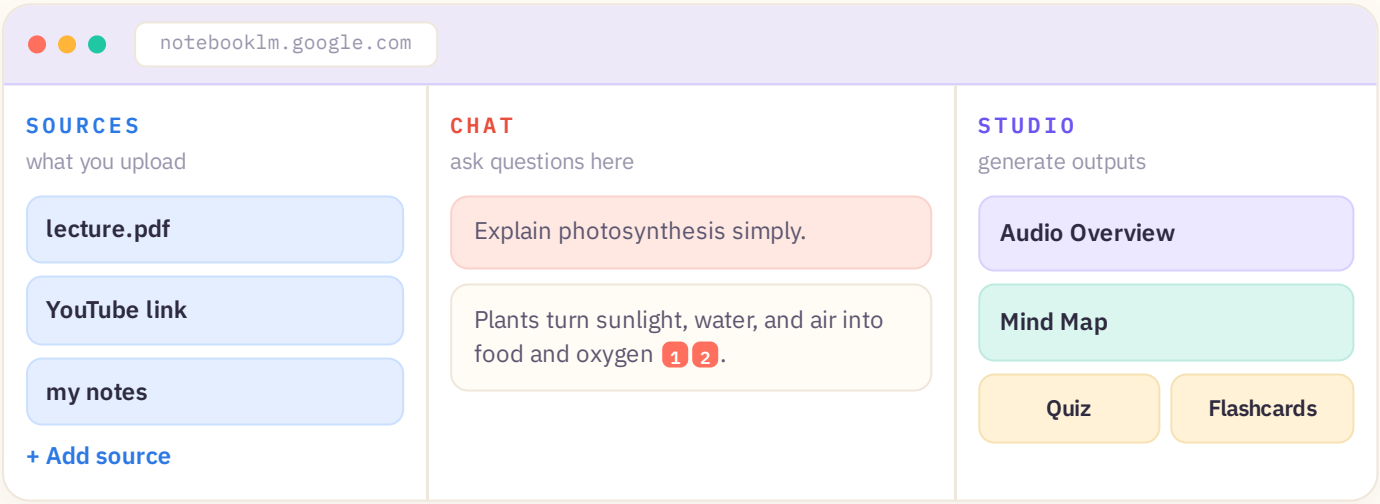
A clean page with a big Create button.
Any old notebooks show up as cards.
No payment screen, no setup,
no credit card needed.

> **One thing you can ignore.** NotebookLM runs on Google's Gemini AI under the hood. You do not need to set up or understand any of that. Sign in and start.

THE MAP OF THE WHOLE TOOL

The screen: Sources, Chat, Studio

Open a notebook and the screen splits into three columns. That is the entire tool. Learn these three and you always know where everything lives.



SOURCES · LEFT
Everything you upload. The answers live in here.

CHAT · MIDDLE
Ask questions, get cited answers from your sources.

STUDIO · RIGHT
One-click outputs: audio, mind maps, quizzes, more.

TWO WORDS TO KNOW

What a notebook and a source actually are

You will see these two words everywhere. Both are simpler than they sound.

A NOTEBOOK

One project about one topic. It holds your sources, your chat, and everything you generate. Think of it as a folder for a single subject.

A SOURCE

One piece of material you add: a PDF, a YouTube video, an article, your notes. NotebookLM reads only your sources, nothing else.

THE GOLDEN RULE

One notebook per topic. Not a giant "College" notebook. Make it "Operating Systems Unit 3". Tight, specific topics give you sharp answers. Broad dumps give you mush.

> **You can have many notebooks.** The free plan allows around a hundred. So do not be shy. One per chapter, one per video rabbit hole, one per project is exactly right.

FEED IT

Add your first sources

Click Add source in the Sources panel. A box opens with everything you can add. You do not need a file for all of them. You can paste a link, or even raw text.

PDF / Word	**Upload from your device.** Slides, papers, your own notes.
YouTube	**Paste the video link.** It reads the transcript for you.
Website	**Paste any article URL.** It pulls in the page text.
Drive	**Pull Google Docs and Slides** straight from your Drive.
Paste text	**Drop in raw notes** or any chunk of text by hand.
Discover	**Let NotebookLM find sources** on the web for you, then add them.

> **A few gotchas.** It cannot read Excel or Google Sheets directly, so save those as CSV first. Scanned image-only PDFs often fail to read. Paywalled pages will not import. If a source shows an error icon, swap it for another.

DO THIS NOW

Add three sources to your notebook: one video, one article or PDF, and a quick paste of your own rough notes. That mix is enough to start.

THE TRUST FEATURE

Citations: click the number, see the proof

This is the feature that makes NotebookLM worth using. Most answers come with little numbered chips. Click one and it jumps you to the exact line in your source that the answer used.

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE IN AN ANSWER

The leaf cells capture sunlight using chlorophyll [1], and release oxygen as a by-product [2]. Most of this happens in the chloroplasts [3].

WHY THIS CHANGES HOW YOU LEARN

You never have to take the AI's word for it. Click the chip, read the original line in your source, and decide for yourself. That click is the difference between learning and blindly copying.

DO THIS NOW

Ask your notebook any question, then click a citation chip in the answer. Watch it open the source and highlight the exact spot. Do this a few times until it feels normal.

TWO WAYS TO GET OUTPUT

Type it in Chat, or click it in Studio

New people get confused here, so let us make it dead simple. There are two ways to get things out of NotebookLM, and each is good at different things.

CHAT · YOU TYPE

Ask a question or make a custom request in your own words. Best for specific questions and tailored asks. Every answer is cited.

STUDIO · YOU CLICK

Click a tile to generate a ready made format: Audio Overview, Mind Map, Quiz, Flashcards, Reports, Slides, Video Overview. One click each.

RULE OF THUMB

A specific question or custom request goes in **Chat**. A whole study asset, like a podcast, a quiz, or a mind map, is one click in **Studio**. You will bounce between both constantly, and that is normal.

> **Good news for beginners.** Most Studio outputs let you add a short instruction before generating, so you still get to steer them. More on that in Part 4.

THE HONEST PAGE

Free, private, and the limits

Straight answers to the three things beginners actually worry about. No fine print games.

IS IT FREE?

Yes. Free with a Google account. The free plan gives around 100 notebooks, up to 50 sources each, and roughly 50 questions a day. Plenty for a student. Paid Google AI plans just raise those limits.

IS IT PRIVATE?

Google says it does not use your uploaded sources to train its AI, and your notebooks are private unless you choose to share one. Still, as with any cloud tool, do not upload anything truly secret.

WHAT ARE THE LIMITS?

Each source can be huge, up to 500,000 words. The free plan caps daily questions and audio generations. If you hit a cap, wait a day or split your material across more notebooks.

> **These numbers move fast.** Google changes the plans and limits often. Treat the figures here as roughly true, and check the current limits inside the app if it matters for your work.

PUT IT TOGETHER

Your first notebook in 10 minutes

Everything so far, in one short run. Do this once and the tool stops feeling abstract.

1. **Create and name it**
   Click Create. Name it for one topic, like "Photosynthesis Class 10".
2. **Add 3 to 7 sources**
   A video, an article or your slides, and your own notes.
3. **Ask for a source map**
   In Chat, paste the prompt below before anything else.
4. **Generate one output**
   In Studio, click one tile. Try a Quiz, or a Study Guide under Reports.
5. **Check a citation**
   Click a chip in any answer to confirm it against your source.

first prompt, paste in chat

```
I am new to this topic. First scan all my sources.
Tell me: 1) what each source is about, 2) the 10 most
important ideas, 3) what I should learn first, 4) what is
missing from my sources, 5) five questions I should ask next.
```

PART 02

The source stack

NotebookLM is only as good as what you feed it. This short part is the highest-leverage habit in the whole guide: building a small, balanced set of sources before you ask anything.

13 Your sources decide everything

14 The balanced source stack

15 Mistakes that ruin answers

THE ONE HABIT THAT MATTERS MOST

Your sources decide everything

One weak source gives weak answers. A small, balanced stack gives answers you can trust and actually learn from. This is where most people go wrong, before they type a single prompt.

WEAK STACK

One random blog, or only screenshots, with no goal. NotebookLM has almost nothing to work with, so the answers are thin and generic.

STRONG STACK

A simple explainer, a deeper source, an official one, and your own notes. Now it can compare, connect, and answer with real depth.

> **But do not dump 40 files either.** Three to ten focused sources beat a giant messy pile. Balance and relevance win, not raw quantity. More junk just dilutes the good stuff.

THE RECIPE

The balanced source stack

Aim for this mix on any topic. Each source plays a different role, and together they give NotebookLM enough context to actually teach you.

1. BEGINNER EXPLAINER
A simple video or article. Builds your basic context first.

2. A DEEPER SOURCE
A lecture, paper, or long article. This is the real depth.

3. AN OFFICIAL SOURCE
A textbook section or official doc. Your ground truth.

4. YOUR OWN NOTES
What you already think or understand, even if rough.

5. YOUR QUESTION LIST
Paste the things you actually want to solve. This points the AI at what matters to you.

WHY IT WORKS
Different angles let NotebookLM cross-check and show you where sources agree or clash.

DO THIS NOW Build this exact stack for your topic. Even if you only manage three of the five, you are already far ahead of dumping one random link.

WEAK STACKS

Source mistakes that ruin answers

If your answers feel shallow, it is almost always one of these. Check this list before you blame the tool.

- Uploading **only screenshots** or image-only PDFs that cannot be read properly.
- Relying on **one random blog** instead of a balanced mix.
- Adding sources with **no goal or question** attached.
- Dumping everything in **without naming the topic** of the notebook.
- Asking for the **final answer too early**, before it has even organised your sources.

> **The fix for all five is the same.** A few good sources, a clearly named topic, and a goal in mind. Get the inputs right and the outputs fix themselves.

PART 03

Learning workflows

Six exact workflows for real situations: a video you want to understand, an exam you need to pass, a topic you want to argue both sides of, and content you want to make. Copy the prompts, then make them yours.

16 Learn from a video

17 Exam mode

18 Tutor mode

19 Debate mode

20 Creator mode

21 Audio and Video Overviews

WORKFLOW 1

Learn any topic from a video

For YouTube lectures, documentaries, podcasts, and explainers. The trick: do not ask for a summary. Ask it to teach you, step by step.

1. PICK TOPIC
Example: 5 inventions humans still cannot recreate.

2. ADD SOURCE
Video link plus one or two articles for balance.

3. ASK TO LEARN
Use tutor prompts, not "summarize this".

video learning prompt

```
I am learning this topic from my sources. Do not just
summarize. Teach it to me step by step. Start with a simple
explanation, then the 5 most surprising points, then what
most beginners misunderstand, then 10 questions to check
if I understood it.
```

GOOD FOLLOW-UPS

Explain point 3 with a real example. · Where in my sources is this mentioned, with citations? · Make a 15-minute revision plan from this.

WORKFLOW 2

Exam mode

Turn class notes and PDFs into a revision machine. Best for college chapters, lecture slides, papers, and long textbook sections.

1. ORGANISE FIRST

Upload slides, notes, previous year questions, and the syllabus portion. Make NotebookLM organise it before you ask for answers.

2. THEN TEST YOURSELF

Generate quizzes, get wrong answers explained, build a weak-topic list, and revise only what you keep missing.

exam mode prompt

```
Act as my exam tutor. From my sources, create: 1) a one-page
cheat sheet, 2) a beginner explanation of the chapter, 3) 20
exam-style questions, 4) an answer key with source citations,
5) what to revise first if I only have 2 hours.
```

Revision rule. Do not re-read summaries again and again. Ask a question, answer it yourself first, then check. Use NotebookLM to find your weak spots. Use your own brain to fix them.

WORKFLOW 3

Tutor mode: do not get spoon-fed

The best learning prompt forces you to think before it explains. Use this when you genuinely want to understand, not just finish an assignment.

1. **Ask me first**
   It poses a question and does not reveal the answer yet.
2. **Hint, then stronger hint**
   If you are wrong, it nudges you instead of just telling you.
3. **Explain**
   Only now does it explain the concept fully.
4. **Test again**
   It asks a fresh question, then maps your weak areas.

active learning prompt

```
Act like a patient tutor. Ask me one question at a time and
wait for my answer. If I am wrong, give a hint before
explaining. Use only my sources. After 5 questions, summarize
my weak areas and give a short revision plan.
```

WORKFLOW 4

Debate mode

A topic becomes clear when you can argue for and against it. Use this for history, economics, politics, business cases, essays, and content ideas.

SIDE A · FOR

The strongest arguments that support the claim, with the best evidence pulled from your sources.

SIDE B · AGAINST

The strongest arguments against it, again backed by what your sources actually say.

debate prompt

```
Create a debate from my sources. Topic: [insert topic].
Give me: 1) strongest argument for, 2) strongest argument
against, 3) where both sides agree, 4) where the sources are
weak, 5) what a smart person would still be unsure about.
```

Creator use. This is how you make non-generic reels. Not "AI is useful", but real tension: what people think versus what is actually true. Tension is what makes people stop scrolling.

WORKFLOW 5

Creator mode

Understand first, then turn that understanding into content. This is how a student builds a real brand instead of posting shallow AI tool lists.

source → insight → angle → script

creator mode prompt

```
From my sources, find 10 content ideas a smart student or
creator would save. For each: a hook, why it matters, one
example, one mistake people make, and a 30-second reel
script in Hinglish. Avoid generic gyaan.
```

> **Best content comes from specifics.** Bad: "NotebookLM saves time." Good: "Turn one boring PDF into a quiz, a debate, an audio overview, and a reel script in 20 minutes." Specific is what gets saved and shared.

WORKFLOW 6

Audio and Video Overviews

Audio Overview turns your sources into a podcast-style chat between AI hosts. Video Overview makes narrated slides. Both are one click in Studio. Great for revision walks, the gym, or a commute.

WHEN TO USE IT

After you have strong sources and roughly know what you want. Best for overview and revision, not as your only source of truth.

HOW TO GUIDE IT

Before generating, tell it the level, focus, and length. In English you can even join the audio live and ask the hosts a question by voice.

audio overview prompt

```
Create an Audio Overview for a beginner who has 20 minutes.
Focus on the 5 ideas most likely to appear in an exam.
Use simple examples, avoid unnecessary history, and end with
5 questions I should be able to answer.
```

One catch. An overview is made once and does not update when you add new sources later, so regenerate it. And if something sounds surprising, ask in chat: where exactly is this in my sources?

PART 04

Outputs, prompts, trust

Turn one notebook into many outputs, write prompts that actually work, and build the one habit that separates smart users from people who blindly copy confident answers.

22 One notebook, many outputs

23 The 5-part prompt formula

24 Copy-paste prompt library

25 How to avoid fake confidence

26 Full worked example

ONE TOPIC, MANY OUTPUTS

One notebook, many outputs

Do not stop at a summary. The Studio panel turns the same sources into many formats with one click each. Pick by your goal.

AUDIO / VIDEO OVERVIEW
Podcast or narrated slides. For passive revision.

MIND MAP
A visual map of how ideas connect. Click to explore.

QUIZ / FLASHCARDS
Test memory and understanding. For active recall.

REPORTS
Study guides, briefings, timelines, and FAQs live here.

SLIDE DECK / INFOGRAPHIC
Polished visuals for presentations or posts.

REEL SCRIPT
Not a Studio tile. Ask for this in Chat (see Workflow 5).

output chooser prompt

```
From this notebook, recommend the best 3 outputs for my goal:
[exam / content / research / presentation]. Explain why each
helps and what prompt I should use next.
```

STOP ASKING VAGUE QUESTIONS

The 5-part prompt formula

Good prompts tell NotebookLM the role, goal, level, evidence rule, and output. Use this whenever you are stuck on what to type.

1. ROLE
Act as my exam tutor / debate coach / content strategist.

2. GOAL
I want to understand / revise / create / compare.

3. LEVEL
Beginner / intermediate / college student.

4. EVIDENCE
Use only my sources and cite where possible.

5. OUTPUT
Give it as a table / bullets / quiz / script / checklist.

master template

```
Act as my [role]. My goal is [goal]. Assume I am at [level].
Use only my sources and cite the source on any important
claim. Give the output as [format]. End with 3 next questions
I should ask.
```

SAVE THIS PAGE

Copy-paste prompt library

When you do not know what to ask next, grab one of these and replace the brackets with your topic or goal.

BEGINNER
Explain [topic] like I am learning it for the first time. Use simple examples and cite the source for important points.

DEEP DIVE
Go beyond summary. What are the hidden patterns, surprising ideas, and important contradictions in my sources?

QUIZ
Create 15 questions from easy to hard. Wait for my answers before showing the answer key.

WEAKNESS FINDER
Test me on this topic and identify exactly what I do not understand yet.

CREATOR
Turn the useful insights into 5 reel ideas with a hook, an example, and a caption angle.

PRESENTATION
Create a 5-slide outline with title, key points, an example, and speaker notes.

TRUST, BUT VERIFY

How to avoid fake confidence

NotebookLM is source-grounded, but you still need a checking habit. Confident does not always mean correct. These four questions keep you honest.

ASK FOR EVIDENCE
Where exactly is this said in my sources? Is this a direct statement or your inference?

ASK FOR UNCERTAINTY
What is missing from my sources? Which claims are weakly supported?

ASK FOR DISAGREEMENT
Do any sources disagree? What would a critic say? What is assumed?

ASK FOR ACTION
What should I read next? Make a study plan. Test me on the weak areas.

fact-check prompt

```
Before I use this answer, audit it. Mark each claim as:
directly supported, inferred, weakly supported, or not in
sources. Give citations for the important claims.
```

THE WHOLE SYSTEM, ONE TOPIC

From a random topic to deep learning

Here is everything put together on one fun topic: 5 inventions humans still cannot recreate. Use it as a template for anything you find interesting.

TOPIC
5 inventions humans still cannot recreate.

SOURCES
Video, article, your notes, your questions.

OUTPUTS
Timeline, quiz, debate, reel script.

example prompt 1, in chat

```
Make a table: invention, what it was, why it is hard to
recreate, what evidence my sources give, one modern
comparison. Then 5 beginner and 5 deep questions.
```

example prompt 2, in chat

```
Now turn this into a 30-second Hinglish reel script for
students. Hook should create curiosity. Avoid generic lines
like "AI is the future".
```

PART 05

Make it a habit

Knowing the tool is not the same as using it. This part turns NotebookLM from a thing you read about into part of how you learn every week.

27 5 notebooks to build today

28 The 7-day challenge

29 Common mistakes and fixes

30 Your repeatable loop

NO MORE BLANK PAGE

5 notebooks you can build today

The fastest way to learn NotebookLM is to make one small useful notebook. Pick one of these and build it now.

1. EXAM CHAPTER

Sources: slides, notes, PYQs, syllabus. Output: quiz plus cheat sheet.

2. CREATOR RESEARCH

Sources: videos, articles, your observations. Output: hooks plus scripts.

3. CAREER SKILL

Sources: roadmap, docs, tutorials. Output: a 14-day plan.

4. BOOK / PODCAST

Sources: highlights, transcript, notes. Output: insights plus actions.

5. BUSINESS / STARTUP

Sources: competitors, market notes, user pain points. Output: a strategy brief.

DO THIS NOW Pick the one that matches something real in your life this week and build it before you turn the page. Future you will thank present you.

ONE WEEK TO FLUENT

The 7-day NotebookLM challenge

Simple daily tasks. No overthinking. By day 7 it is a habit, not a tutorial.

- **Day 1.** Create one notebook and add 3 sources.
- **Day 2.** Ask for a source map and the 10 key ideas.
- **Day 3.** Generate a study guide and a quiz.
- **Day 4.** Use tutor mode for 20 minutes.
- **Day 5.** Create an Audio Overview or a briefing.
- **Day 6.** Turn the topic into a reel or carousel script.
- **Day 7.** Audit what was useful and save your own prompt set.

day 7 review prompt

```
Analyze my week with NotebookLM. Which workflows helped most,
which prompts were weak, and what repeatable system should I
use next week?
```

DO NOT WASTE THE TOOL

Common mistakes beginners make

Most people use NotebookLM like a summary machine. That is the lowest-value use. Avoid these five and your results jump immediately.

Only asking "summarize this"

Fix: ask for questions, examples, disagreements, and action steps instead.

Uploading weak sources

Fix: use a balanced stack, not one random link. See Part 2.

Not setting a goal

Fix: exam, reel, research, and presentation each need different outputs.

Trusting without checking

Fix: click citations and ask it to mark weak claims.

Reading passively

Fix: use quiz and tutor mode. Answer before you check.

THE WHOLE GUIDE IN ONE PAGE

Your repeatable NotebookLM loop

Use this loop every time you learn something new. Once it is muscle memory, you have the whole system.



NotebookLM is not just a tool to read faster. It is a system to think better with your own sources. Every time you upload something, ask three things: what should I understand, what should I question, and what should I create from this?

You now have the full system. The screen, the source stack, the workflows, the prompts, and the checking habit. The only thing left is to open it and build your first real notebook. Next page.

YOUR NEXT ACTION

Build one notebook today

Do not try to learn every feature first. Open NotebookLM, make one notebook on one real topic, add three sources, and paste the prompt below. That is the whole start.

TINY FIRST ACTION / COPY THIS

```
Scan all my sources. Tell me what each one is about, the 10 most important ideas, what I should learn first, and 5 questions I should ask next. Cite the sources.
```

Sources in. Questions. Understanding. Output.

AI WITH MUDIT

DM "LEARN"